the fort that the Early Chalukyas followed Buddhist example by digging into the yellow sandstone to create three rock-cut caves, each following the well-established pattern of a pillared verandah at the front that opened into a square chamber supported by more pillars.

The first of these caves, Cave 1, was dedicated to Lord Shiva, and of particular interest to us here because of the carving on the wall immediately to the right as you enter. At 5 feet in height and breadth, it is modest in comparison to what came slightly later at the far more ambitious rock-cut Shiva temple on Elephanta Island in Bombay Harbour, but it is generally considered to be the earliest portrayal of Shiva as Nataraja – because he is quite clearly dancing, with two arms held out in front and turned in at the elbows, the right hand turned outward with palm exposed, the left turned down and inward, and one foot poised on its toes, as if about to be dance in the posture of *ghurnita* or 'thinking' found in the Indian classic dance form known as Bharatnatyam that originated in the temples of South India. But there are more hands too, eighteen in all, arranged in a semi-circular fan around his body to suggest both multiplicity and motion, because this is the cosmic cycle.

Also to be found in the same chamber is another bas-relief which is literally half Shiva and half Vishnu, in the fused composite known as Harihara. This rather nicely sets the scene for the second cave to be built, cut into the stone just above the first. This is largely given over to Lord Vishnu, as indeed is the third cave, Cave 3. This is the last, largest and most elaborately decorated of the three and it is the only one to carry a dated inscription, which names its consecration as taking place on the day of the full moon on the local calendar equivalent of 1 November 578.[4] This places it in the reign of the second of the Chalukya kings, Kirtivarman, which suggests that it was his successor